NON-EFFECTIVE FINITE EQUIVALENCE RELATIONS ON FINITE SCHEMES OVER A FIELD: VENKEN'S EXAMPLE CHECKED, AND A SECOND ONE

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Abstract. In 1961 Grothendieck asked whether a closed equivalence relation on a finite scheme over a field, with finite but not necessarily flat projections, is always effective. In a lecture at Buffalo in 1973 he still called the question open. It had been answered in the negative in 1971 by Venken, in a two-page note about the descent of flat modules whose Corollary 3.1 is a non-effective equivalence relation on the spectrum of a local Artin algebra of dimension 33 in six variables, over any field. We recheck Venken's example by linear algebra: the ideal of his relation exceeds, by one dimension in degree 4, the ideal of $X \times_Y X$, where Y is the quotient. We then give a second example in two variables, of length 15, obtained by restricting Raicu's non-effective relation on the affine plane to a finite subscheme cut out by squares of invariant functions. For this one the comparison is carried out over $\mathbb{Q}$, the primes dividing a pivot are recorded, and those characteristics are checked separately, so that it holds over every field.

1. The question

Let k be a field, $X = \operatorname{Spec} A$ a finite k-scheme and $R \subset X \times_k X$ a closed subscheme whose points with values in every k-algebra form an equivalence relation. Its projections $R \rightrightarrows X$ are finite, but they need not be flat. The ring of invariants

$$B = A^R = \{\, a \in A : a \otimes 1 - 1 \otimes a \in I_R \,\},$$

with $I_R \subset A \otimes_k A$ the ideal of R, is a finite k-algebra, and $Y = \operatorname{Spec} B$ is the quotient of X by R in the category of schemes. The relation is *effective* when the morphism $R \to X \times_Y X$ is an isomorphism.

In the third of his talks on the construction of schemes, after the flat case, Grothendieck wrote that without flatness he did not know whether a finite equivalence relation is effective. He reduced the question to the spectrum of a local Artin ring with algebraically closed residue field, and said that it was open even over a field [3, §2, p. 212-05]. The flat case is SGA 3, exp. V [8].

The answer is in print. Venken's note of 1971 [9], presented to the Académie on 5 April 1971, is titled after the descent of flat modules, and most of it is about modules: it constructs a finite injective morphism f of local Artin rings which is a descent morphism for flat modules, and a descent datum on a free module which is not effective. On the way, its Corollary 3.1 states that a certain ideal of $B \otimes_A B$ is an equivalence ideal and that the equivalence relation it defines is not effective (his B is our A, and his A a subring of it). The ring is a local Artin algebra over an arbitrary field K, with residue field K, so this is a negative answer to the question over every field. Venken takes his definitions from Grothendieck's first talk on descent [2].

Two years later, at the end of a lecture of his algebraic geometry course at the State University of New York at Buffalo, on 11 July 1973, a listener asked for open problems and he gave this one: he said it was not known, that he expected the answer to be negative, and that it was very elementary [1]. In the appendix to Kollár's paper on quotients by finite

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equivalence relations, Raicu gave finite equivalence relations on $\mathbb{A}^2$ which are not effective [4, §50], and affine toric equivalence relations are effective [6]. Philippe studied descent along unramified morphisms [5].

This note does two things. Section 3 checks Venken's Corollary 3.1 by machine, since his note gives it in one line after a cohomological computation. Sections 4 and 5 give a second example, smaller and in two variables, from Raicu's relation.

Theorem 1 (Venken, 1971)**.** *Let K be any field. There is a local Artin K-algebra of dimension 33, with residue field K, and a closed equivalence relation on its spectrum, with finite projections, which is not effective.*

Theorem 2. *Let k be any field. There is a graded local Artin k-algebra of dimension 15 with two generators, with residue field k, and a closed equivalence relation on its spectrum, with finite projections, which is not effective.*

Both examples also answer the more general question, for X finite over a noetherian base.

2. Effectivity as linear algebra

With the notation of the question, $X \times_Y X = \operatorname{Spec}(A \otimes_B A)$ and $A \otimes_B A = (A \otimes_k A)/J_B$, where J_B is the ideal generated by the $b \otimes 1 - 1 \otimes b$, $b \in B$. By definition of B, $J_B \subseteq I_R$, and $R \to X \times_Y X$ is the closed immersion defined by I_R/J_B. So R is effective if and only if $I_R = J_B$, a comparison of two subspaces of the finite-dimensional space $A \otimes_k A$.

When A and I_R are graded, B is a graded subalgebra and both ideals are graded, so the comparison can be made degree by degree. A homogeneous invariant of degree e contributes to J_B only in degrees $\geq e$; to compare the two ideals in degree d it suffices to know the invariants of degree at most d.

3. Venken's example

Let K be a field. In Venken's notation [9], $\mathbf{B} = K[M, N, X, Y, Z, W]/\mathbf{I}$, where $\mathbf{I}$ is generated by

$$M^2,\ MN,\ N^2,\ X^3,\ Y^3,\ Z^3,\ W^3,\ YZ,\ NY,\ MZ,\ NXY,\ MYW$$

and all monomials of degree 3 in X, Y, Z, W; lower-case letters denote the classes. Let $\mathbf{A} \subset \mathbf{B}$ be the subalgebra generated by m, n, mx, nw and $my - nz$. Its maximal ideal has square zero, so $\dim_K \mathbf{A} = 6$. Venken proves that $\mathbf{A} \to \mathbf{B}$ is a descent morphism for flat modules, that $H^1(\mathbf{B}/\mathbf{A}, \mathbb{G}_a) \neq 0$, with $mxy \otimes w$ giving a nonzero class, and deduces:

> *Corollary 3.1.* The ideal $\mathbf{J}$ of $\mathbf{B} \otimes_{\mathbf{A}} \mathbf{B}$ generated by $mxy \otimes w$ is an equivalence ideal, and the equivalence relation it defines is not effective.

As a closed subscheme of $\operatorname{Spec}(\mathbf{B} \otimes_K \mathbf{B})$, this relation R_V has ideal

$$I_V = (a \otimes 1 - 1 \otimes a : a = m, n, mx, nw, my - nz) + (mxy \otimes w),$$

since the first generators cut $\mathbf{B} \otimes_{\mathbf{A}} \mathbf{B}$ out of $\mathbf{B} \otimes_K \mathbf{B}$. Its points are an equivalence relation on $\operatorname{Spec} \mathbf{B}$ over K, and its projections are finite because $\mathbf{B}$ is. All the generators are monomials or binomials of one degree, so the setting of Section 2 applies with every variable of degree 1.

Proposition 3. *Over $\mathbb{Q}$ and over $\mathbb{F}_p$ for $p = 2, 3, 5, 7, 11, 101$:*

1. *$\dim \mathbf{B} = 33$, and $\mathbf{B}$ vanishes in degrees above 3;*
2. *I_V satisfies the three axioms of an equivalence relation: it lies in the kernel of the multiplication, it is stable under the exchange of factors, and its image under p_{13} lies in the sum of its images under p_{12} and p_{23} in $\mathbf{B}^{\otimes 3}$;*
3. *the ring of invariants $\mathbf{B}^{R_V}$ has dimension 10, so it is strictly larger than $\mathbf{A}$;*
4. *I_V and $J_{\mathbf{B}^{R_V}}$ differ only in degree 4, where their dimensions are 269 and 268, and $mxy \otimes w$ does not lie in $J_{\mathbf{B}^{R_V}}$.*

So R_V is not effective in the sense of Section 1, as Venken states. Venken notes that the ideal generated by M^2, MN, N^2 and the monomials of degree 3 in X, Y, Z, W would suffice, the other generators only simplifying his computations. The same check on that ideal gives $\dim \mathbf{B} = 45$, invariants of dimension 8, and again a gap of one dimension in degree 4 ($410 > 409$).

The script `venken.py` of the directory `computations/effective/venken` of the repository [7] works in the monomial basis of $\mathbf{B}^{\otimes 2}$ and $\mathbf{B}^{\otimes 3}$ and performs the comparisons by Gaussian elimination. We did not record its pivots, so for characteristics other than those listed, the statement rests on Venken's proof.

4. Raicu's relation and its restriction

Write $x = (x_1, x_2)$ and $y = (y_1, y_2)$ for the coordinates of $\mathbb{A}^2 \times \mathbb{A}^2$. Raicu's relation [4, §50] is the closed subscheme $R \subset \mathbb{A}^2 \times \mathbb{A}^2$ with ideal

$$I = \left(x_1^2 - y_1^2,\ x_1x_2 - x_2^2 - y_1y_2 + y_2^2,\ x_2^3 - y_2^3,\ (x_1y_2 - x_2y_1)\, y_2^3\right) \subset k[x_1, x_2, y_1, y_2].$$

It is a finite equivalence relation on $\mathbb{A}^2$, defined over $\mathbb{Z}$, and it is not effective after base change to any field; the class of $(x_1y_2 - x_2y_1)\, y_2^3$ is the obstruction. The functions

$$f_1 = x_1^2, \qquad f_2 = x_1x_2 - x_2^2, \qquad f_3 = x_2^3$$

are invariant, since $f_i(x) - f_i(y)$ is one of the first three generators of I. Let

$$Z = V(f_1^2, f_2^2, f_3^2) \subset \mathbb{A}^2, \qquad A = k[x_1, x_2]/(f_1^2, f_2^2, f_3^2).$$

Since $f_1^2 = x_1^4$ and $f_3^2 = x_2^6$, Z is supported at the origin, and A is a local Artin algebra with residue field k; a count of monomials shows that $\dim_k A = 15$. Let $R_Z = R \cap (Z \times Z)$, the closed subscheme of $Z \times Z$ with ideal I_{R_Z}, the image of I in $A \otimes_k A$.

Lemma 4. *R_Z is a closed equivalence relation on Z with finite projections.*

Proof. For every k-algebra T, $R_Z(T) = R(T) \cap (Z(T) \times Z(T))$ is the restriction of an equivalence relation on $\mathbb{A}^2(T)$ to the subset $Z(T)$, hence an equivalence relation. R_Z is closed in $Z \times Z$, which is finite over Z by either projection. □

The restriction to Z is what lets a question about $\mathbb{A}^2$ be asked about a finite scheme. It is not formal that non-effectivity survives it: the ring of invariants of R_Z is computed on A, not on $k[x_1, x_2]$, and it can be larger than the image of the invariants on $\mathbb{A}^2$, so that J_B can grow. The next section shows that it does not grow enough.

5. The computation

All the ideals above are homogeneous for the standard grading. In $k[x, y] = k[x_1, x_2, y_1, y_2]$ put $K = (f_1^2, f_2^2, f_3^2)(x) + (f_1^2, f_2^2, f_3^2)(y)$, so that $A \otimes_k A = k[x, y]/K$. The ideal of R_Z lifts to $I + K$, and J_B lifts to $J + K$, where J is generated by the $b(x) - b(y)$ for b running over homogeneous lifts of a basis of B.

Proposition 5. *Over $\mathbb{Q}$ and over every finite prime field, the invariants of R_Z of degree at most 7 give 27 independent differences $b(x) - b(y)$ modulo $I + K$, and in the degrees $d \leq 14$ the two ideals differ only in degree 5, where*

$$\dim_k (I + K)_5 = 52 > 51 = \dim_k (J + K)_5.$$

By the remark at the end of Section 2, invariants of degree at least 8 do not change $J + K$ in degree 5, so the strict inequality in degree 5 proves that R_Z is not effective. A witness is the generator $(x_1y_2 - x_2y_1)\, y_2^3$ of I, Raicu's obstruction: it lies in $(I+K)_5$ and not in $(J+K)_5$, as we checked over $\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathbb{F}_2$ and $\mathbb{F}_3$.

The proposition is a finite computation: the degree-d parts are spanned by monomial multiples of the generators, the invariants of degree d are the kernel of a linear map on the forms of degree d in x, and the dimensions are ranks. The script `scan.py` of the directory

`computations/effective/raicu` of the repository [7], run with `EXP=2,2,2`, performs it by Gaussian elimination over $\mathbb{Q}$ or over $\mathbb{F}_p$.

Proof that it holds over every field. A field k contains $\mathbb{Q}$ or some $\mathbb{F}_p$, and all the data are defined over the prime field: ranks and kernels of matrices with entries in the prime field do not change under extension of scalars. It remains to cover every prime field.

Over $\mathbb{Q}$ the elimination divides only by pivots. Each coefficient it produces is an integer combination of the input coefficients, all integers, divided by a product of pivots. If a prime p divides neither the numerator nor the denominator of any pivot, the same sequence of operations is defined over $\mathbb{F}_p$, with the same pivot positions, and gives the same ranks and the same kernels. The script `certify_scan.py` reruns the computation over $\mathbb{Q}$ and records the prime factors of all pivots; they are $2, 3, 5, 7, 13, 41$ and 61. For every other prime the proposition over $\mathbb{F}_p$ follows from the one over $\mathbb{Q}$. For these seven primes `scan.py` was run directly over $\mathbb{F}_p$, with the same result. □

Remark 6. Why this Z. Among the subschemes $V(f_1^a, f_2^b, f_3^c)$ with $a, b, c \leq 3$, sixteen were tried over $\mathbb{F}_3$, and the smallest on which the obstruction survives is $a = b = c = 2$; with exponents $(3, 3, 2)$ one gets length 27, with gaps in degrees 5 and 6. Whether a shorter example exists, from other ideals, is not known. A random search over 48 small monomial algebras over $\mathbb{F}_2$ and $\mathbb{F}_3$ found no non-effective relation; Raicu's theorem that affine toric equivalence relations are effective [6] suggests why. Compared with Venken's example, this one has length 15 against 33 and two generators against six; Venken's has the advantage of a proof by hand.

Remark 7. Grothendieck reduced the question to an algebraically closed residue field; both examples have residue field k, which may be chosen algebraically closed. Both are also graded, which the question does not require.

What is not done. The computations are not formalised: a Lean proof would need either a certified Gaussian elimination over $\mathbb{Q}$ and the pivot primes, or a Gröbner-basis certificate. The pivots of the check of Venken's example were not recorded. The second example has not been checked by a specialist of descent, and no conceptual proof of it, for instance by transporting Raicu's Amitsur cocycle to Z, is given.

Use of language models. The question was located in the recording of the Buffalo lecture and in [3] with language models (Claude Opus 5.5, Anthropic), which also found Raicu's example, proposed the restriction to Z, wrote the scripts and a first draft of this text, under the author's direction. Venken's note was read on Gallica, and its Corollary 3.1 found to answer the question, after the first version of this text had claimed the case of a finite scheme over a field to be new. The propositions rest on the scripts, which anyone can rerun.

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